

‘What an inspiration and I wish Emily all the best with her saving. Not many people can live on \$200 per week. I hope she can celebrate her achievements very soon.’

I understand the negativity. The point of my column confession was to own up to my mistakes; doing so would hold me accountable for them. And I hoped others, with similar habits and flaws, would learn from my financial flubs.

In the early days of my slide into insolvency and money misdemeanours, I was the fashion editor for Australia’s largest daily newspaper, Melbourne’s *Herald Sun*, and was presenting on Network Ten’s morning show *The Circle*. At each week’s live taping, I took my seat on the studio couch and, blow-waved and wearing a borrowed outfit to look the part, passionately told the audience what they should be buying. I spruiked an endless carousel of ‘must-haves’, from slimming jeans to Kate Middleton– inspired frocks and handbags *en vogue*.

Away from the cameras I was practising what I preached. If I had \$20 left in my wallet before payday, I would set my mind on finding something worth exactly that to buy – an umpteenth T-shirt, yet another lipstick, or an op shop raid for a vintage frock. I didn’t care what it was.

I sorted the spillover from my wardrobe, kept in a storage cage in the basement of my apartment block, by season. When I shifted to a new rental, the removalists were shocked by the skyscraper of large plastic tubs that I had stacked and labelled ‘going-out shoes’, ‘summer work clothes’ and ‘best jackets’, for example. Myer or David Jones could have opened a new womenswear department with my haul.

‘I have never, ever seen this before,’ Mr Removalist said, shaking his head as he heaved ‘winter tops’ into the back of the truck.

Late one night in 2015, I was recognised by a *Circle* viewer – a girl barely out of her teens – as I walked past Melbourne’s Christian Dior boutique, at the swish end of Collins Street. I might have paused to press my nose against the glass, tempted by the stilettos and miniskirts like a pup that had caught a whiff of sausages and mince outside a butcher’s shop.

‘I buy everything you say to,’ the girl told me, and hoisted her skirt to reveal the same brand of patterned tights I had talked about on the previous week’s episode of the show. ‘*Everything*.’ But I wasn’t flattered or proud.